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Source: *Religious Studies*, Mar., 1980, Vol. 16, No. 1 (Mar., 1980), pp. 69-79

Published by: Cambridge University Press

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/20005632>

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RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE IN LONERGAN AND WHITEHEAD

This comparison of some aspects of the treatment of religious experience in the writings of Bernard Lonergan and Alfred North Whitehead is intended to be a contribution to the continuing dialogue between process thought and classical theism, especially as the latter is represented in proponents of a newer or renewed Thomism. Continued exchange will hopefully be fruitful for the common theistic task, as well as a source of insight on the problems and limitations faced by each approach.

The choice of religious experience as the focus for the comparison is in response to the shift in Lonergan's thinking evident in his later works. In the fall of 1972, while delivering a series of lectures on the relationship between religious experience, philosophy of God, and the area of systematic theology, Lonergan remarked that he had come to see that chapter nineteen of his book, *Insight*, where he outlines a philosophy of God, was marked by a key incongruity. In his words, this consisted in the fact that 'while my cognitional theory was based on a long and methodical appeal to experience, in contrast my account of God's existence and attributes made no appeal to religious experience'.¹ Lonergan therefore gives key importance to religious experience and religious conversion in the development of his *Method in Theology*; they are the basis and starting point for a philosophy of God. The fundamental and primary meaning of the name, God, is given in the experience of religious conversion. That fundamental meaning is transcendent mystery, transcendent unknown.² Religious experience gives rise to the question of God; it also provides a new horizon within which questions about God have significance.

Religion was of the highest importance for Whitehead as well, and he believed that his metaphysics must be able to do justice to religious as well as scientific experience. Although discussions germane to his understanding of religion and the concept of God appear in all of his major works, my

¹ Bernard J. F. Lonergan, S.J., *Philosophy of God and Theology* (Philadelphia: The Westminster Press, 1973), p. 12. The shift in Lonergan's thinking is dated from the years 1964–5. See F. E. Crowe, 'Early Jottings on Bernard Lonergan's *Method in Theology*', *Science et Esprit*, xxv (1973), 121–38; and Lonergan, *A Second Collection*, ed. by William F. J. Ryan, S.J. and Bernard J. Tyrrell, S.J. (Philadelphia: The Westminster Press, 1974), 'Introduction'.

² Lonergan, *Method in Theology* (New York: Herder and Herder, 1973), pp. 340–2.

reflections are based most directly on his treatments of the subject in *Religion in the Making* and *Adventures of Ideas*.

Religious experience is both a source of insight and a field of application for Whitehead's philosophy of God; the relationship is one of mutual dependence.

Thus rational religion must have recourse to metaphysics for a scrutiny of its terms. At the same time it contributes its own independent evidence, which metaphysics must take account of in framing its description.¹

Whitehead believed that unless the general description of experience requires an ordering factor, religious experiences are without meaning.² The metaphysical provides a basis for understanding the more specific religious descriptions. But metaphysics is only a first step; particular experiences must be the source of further knowledge of God.

Initial reflection on the statements which Lonergan and Whitehead make regarding religious experience reveals one of the basic ways in which their systems are parallel. For both, the concreteness of the experiencing subject is central. Just as Lonergan's cognitional theory is based on a transcendental turn to the subject, so according to Whitehead's reformed subjectivist principle, all experience is the experience of subjects.³ Lonergan describes his movement from stress on proofs to religious experience as the basis of theistic reflection, as a shift from the abstract to the concrete. Included in Whitehead's reformed subjectivist principle is his own insistence on the priority of the concrete over the abstract. In addition, the shifts in Lonergan's thinking entailed in the discussions of religious experience in his later writings move him closer in several ways to Whitehead's emphases. But divergences remain in their understanding of the meaning both of experience and its relationship to consciousness, and of the concreteness of the experiencing subject. These affect their treatments of several other issues: the importance of non-discursive forms of language such as myth and symbol, the role of ambiguity and contrast in descriptions of religious experience, and the relationship between solitariness and the communal in religious experience. Following a delineation of the core religious experience according to Lonergan and Whitehead, each of these other issues will be treated in turn.

¹ Alfred North Whitehead, *Religion in the Making* (Cleveland: The World Publishing Company, 1960), p. 76.

² Whitehead, *Science and the Modern World* (New York: The Free Press, 1967), pp. 173-4, 178-9.

³ For a very helpful comparison of this aspect of the thought of Lonergan and Whitehead, see Schubert M. Ogden, 'Lonergan and the Subjectivist Principle', *Language, Truth and Meaning. Papers from the International Lonergan Congress 1970*, ed. by Philip McShane (Notre Dame: University Press, 1972), pp. 218-35.

RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE IN LONERGAN

Lonerган uses the term religious experience to refer to an individual's awareness of being in love with transcendent mystery: 'Being in love with God, as experienced, is being in love in an unrestricted fashion.'¹ Several elements of this description receive repeated emphasis in Lonergan's writings.

Religious experience in itself and in its fruits involves consciousness, but not knowledge; it occurs at what Lonergan describes as the fourth level of intentional consciousness. In speaking of religious experience, Lonergan does not use the term experience with his usual designation of it as the empirical level of intentional consciousness, that 'level on which we sense, perceive, imagine, feel, speak, move'.² When referring to religious experience Lonergan uses experience to mean mere consciousness.³ In religious experience one is dealing with a realm in which love precedes knowledge. Reversing the scholastic axiom, 'Nihil amatum nisi praecognitum', Lonergan contends that knowledge of God emerges from a love which first takes hold of our lives and transforms them. He finds Paschal's statement helpful as a support for his own meaning: 'You would not be seeking me unless you had already found me.'⁴ The key category for religious experience is not intellectual insight; it is unlimited love.

Further, such experience, according to Lonergan, has a content, but no object:

The content is a dynamic state of being in love, and being in love without restriction. It is conscious but it is not known. What it refers to is something that can be inferred insofar as you make it advance from being merely conscious to knowing. And then because it is unrestricted, you can infer that it refers to an absolute being. But the gift of itself does not include these ulterior steps.⁵

Because this love moves beyond knowledge, the object of religious experience is described as uncomprehended mystery. Such experience involves being in love with someone, however, and it is therefore a form of relational consciousness.

This experience is a gift, notionally to be identified with sanctifying grace.⁶ In fact, it is the consciousness of grace, of religious self-transcendence, the foundation of all forms of self-transcendence. Since the experience is a supernatural gift, it is an other-worldly orientation into holiness. Although Lonergan claims that he is describing the common core in all religious experience, he usually refers to it in connection with the New Testament, and frequently cites St Paul's statement in Romans 5: 5 as an expression of

¹ *Method in Theology*, p. 105.

² *Ibid.* p. 9.

³ *Ibid.* pp. 106–7. Cf. Philip J. Mueller, 'Lonergan's Theory of Religious Experience', *Église et Théologie*, 7 (1976), 235–51.

⁴ *Philosophy of God and Theology*, pp. 10, 20. Cf. *Method in Theology*, pp. 115, 122–3.

⁵ *Philosophy of God and Theology*, p. 38.

⁶ *Method in Theology*, p. 289.

it: 'God's love has flooded our inmost heart through the Holy Spirit he has given us'.¹

The fourth level of intentional consciousness is the existential level of evaluation and love. Lonergan therefore speaks of religious experience as the transvaluation of all values.

Like all being in love, as distinct from particular acts of loving, it is a first principle. So far from resulting from our knowledge and choice, it dismantles and abolishes the horizon within which our knowing and choosing went on, and it sets up a new horizon within which the love of God transvalues our values and the eyes of that love transform our knowing.²

The fruits of religious conversion are a joy that can coexist with privation and pain, a more radical peace than the world can give, and a love of neighbour that strives to bring about the Kingdom of God on earth. Religious conversion leads to a transformation which is more on the level of practice than of knowledge.³

WHITEHEAD'S THEORY OF RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE

It is in his emphasis on value and on the extensiveness of love that Lonergan's description of the core religious experience bears most resemblance to Whitehead's. Whitehead's writings contain several different descriptions of religious experience, which are difficult to summarize briefly. However, a key category for Whitehead in the discussion of religious experience is that of value.⁴ The basis for religious assertions is the pervasive experience of values; this common experience of value provides the generic reference for the term, 'God'. In *Religion in the Making* this experience is discussed chiefly in relation to the individual; in *Adventures in Ideas* Whitehead describes the experience of God as the 'Peace' which crowns civilization at its height. Whitehead's philosophical theology offers justification for two cravings: novelty or freshness, and permanence. The power of God operates in a person's life in a stream of conditions and events, processes and powers, which his conscious knowledge is able to sense only vaguely. It is possible, however, to have a direct experience of God as the source of order and novelty, and to have feelings as a result of it which indicate the divine presence.⁵ Whitehead describes religious experience in *Religion in the Making* as the intuition of immediate occasions as failing or succeeding in reference to a relevant ideal: 'So far as the conformity is incomplete, there is evil in the world.'⁶ Whitehead

¹ *Ibid.* p. 105. Cf. *A Second Collection*, p. 129.

² 'The Response of the Jesuit as Priest and Apostle in the Modern World', *A Second Collection*, p. 172.

³ *Method in Theology*, p. 105; *Philosophy of God and Theology*, p. 36. Cf. Denise Lardner Carmody, 'Lonergan's Religious Person', *Religion in Life*, XLIV (1975), 222-31.

⁴ *Science and the Modern World*, p. 185; *Religion in the Making*, p. 120.

⁵ Cf. John B. Cobb, Jr., *A Christian Natural Theology* (Philadelphia: The Westminster Press, 1965), pp. 225-46.

⁶ P. 60.

goes to some lengths to make the point that there is no direct intuition of a definite person or individual, but rather a rightness in things, partially conformed to and partially disregarded.¹ Deity or God accounts for importance, value, and a sense of worth beyond ourselves. The awareness of existing in terms of unrealized possibilities indicates a realm transcending individual personality.²

Whitehead also attempts to identify the transcendent dimensions of experience in his description of the feeling of peace at the end of *Adventures in Ideas*.³ Such transcendence is a vague sense of the qualification of the finite by a transcendent order, not a clear and distinct expression of a sheer transcendence. Just as Lonergan's 'being in love in an unqualified way' is grace; so also does the peace which Whitehead speaks of come as a gift. As a transcendence beyond self-transcendence, it involves coordinations larger than personality, the appeal beyond boundaries, and a grasp of infinitude. It is 'the zest of self-forgetful transcendence belonging to Civilization at its height'.⁴ God is the source both of the values which move individuals and civilizations, and of their movement toward those values. Both life and thought are sustained by a dim apprehension of the beyond. Whenever and however peace comes, it is the result of an intuition into the final beauty of the universe, and a trust in its efficacy beyond the power of reason to discern the details. It does not arise from cognitive beliefs as such. Just as Lonergan emphasizes that religious experience provides a fresh horizon for living which overcomes the trivializations of life that stem from limited loves, so also Whitehead speaks of peace, or the experience of God, as bringing about an enlarging of one's powers; an expansion of consciousness and the calming of that turbulence which is destructive and inhibiting; and especially growth in the love of humankind as such.⁵

EXPERIENCE AND CONSCIOUSNESS

There are several elements in these descriptions of the core religious experience according to Lonergan and Whitehead which could be pursued further. The focus of this comparison, however, will be on those ways in which Lonergan's shift to religious experience as a starting point moves him closer to some of Whitehead's emphases while at the same time revealing contrasts between his own and Whitehead's account of dimensions of that experience.

Underlying his account of religious experience is Whitehead's conviction that experience involves more than consciousness or knowing. And concreteness encompasses the fullness of such experience. In Whitehead's world view the basic fact is a process of self-realization which arises from previous

¹ *Religion in the Making*, pp. 59–60.

² Whitehead, *Modes of Thought* (New York: The Free Press, 1968), pp. 102–3.

³ (New York: The Free Press, 1967), pp. 284–96.

⁴ *Adventures of Ideas*, pp. 295–6.

⁵ *Ibid.* pp. 285–6.

experience but adds a new individuality and value to the world. According to Whitehead, the realms of experience, thought, and linguistic expression involve a movement from the more fundamental realities to the more distinct and clear. Experience is broader than thought, and thought in turn exceeds the limits of that which can clearly be expressed. Whitehead divides the direct perception of the world, or the awareness of other entities, into the two modes which he calls 'causal efficacy' and 'presentational immediacy'.¹ The feeling of other things as affecting one, or causal efficacy, is the prior and primary factor in perception. Perception begins with the connected and relational, not with separate entities; it begins with the concrete, not with the abstract. God is only experienced in the mode of causal efficacy, and since this is usually the unconscious side of one's experience, it must be brought into awareness. Consciousness can only dimly illumine the mode of causal efficacy. Presentational immediacy, which is a later derivative, is enjoyed with a more vivid consciousness: 'There is a small focal region of clear illumination, and a large penumbral region of experience which tells of intense experience in dim apprehension.'² Whitehead refers to the experience in the mode of causal efficacy as that primitive, vague, haunting and unmanageable experience, which is nonetheless insistent and important.

One presupposition lying behind Lonergan's account, which diverges from Whitehead's, is that all of our experience is conscious experience. Religious experience therefore presupposes consciousness, in contrast to Whitehead's position where consciousness presupposes and can only dimly illumine such experience. However, in describing religious experience, Lonergan makes statements which come close to Whitehead's reading of reality. As was mentioned earlier, Lonergan's focus on religious experience represents a shift from interest in the levels of experiencing, understanding, and judging to the levels of deliberating, evaluating, deciding and loving. This emphasis on intentionality analysis of the fourth level also includes increased concern for affectivity and the feelings that are intentional responses. Lonergan has stated that the knowledge which is born of religious love is what Paschal meant when he remarked that the heart has reasons which reason does not know.³ He clarifies how this relates to his own approach by stating:

... mind is experience, understanding, judgment; and heart is what is beyond this on the level of feeling and 'is this worthwhile?' – judgment of value, decision. Without feelings this experience, understanding, judgment is paper-thin. The whole mass and momentum of living is in feeling.⁴

The divergence between the two approaches is lessened therefore by dimensions of Lonergan's insistence that in the realm of religious experience

¹ Cf. Whitehead, *Symbolism. Its Meaning and Effect* (New York: Capricorn Books, 1959); *Process and Reality. An Essay in Cosmology* (New York: Macmillan Co., 1929), pp. 184 ff., 255 ff.

² *Process and Reality*, p. 408.

³ *Method in Theology*, p. 115.

⁴ 'An Interview With Fr. Bernard Lonergan, S.J.', ed. by Philip McShane, *A Second Collection*, pp. 220–1.

love precedes knowledge, and that such experience lies outside knowledge. Lonergan's interest in the fourth level of intentional consciousness represents a focus on the freedom, responsiveness, and value-relatedness of the individual, emphases also central in Whitehead's account.

However, in describing religious experience, Lonergan indicates that the movement from experience toward knowledge is in the direction of the fuller and larger reality.

To say that this dynamic state is conscious is not to say that it is known. What is conscious, indeed, is experienced. But human knowing is not just experiencing. Human knowing includes experiencing but adds to it attention, scrutiny, inquiry, insight, conception, naming, reflecting, checking, judging. The whole problem of cognitional theory is to effect the transition from operations as experienced to operations as known.¹

Knowledge consists in judgments that are reasonably made as a result of questions which are intelligently put to experience.²

Whitehead also values highly the functions of reason and the clarification they can provide for any experience. He insists that 'religion requires a metaphysical backing; for its authority is endangered by the intensity of the emotions which it generates'.³ But within Whitehead's system the concrete realm of processive relationships remains the fuller reality. Therefore, in spite of strong similarities, the differences in their understandings of the relationships among experience, consciousness, and knowledge, continue to influence the tone of Lonergan and Whitehead's discussions of aspects of religious experience. This can be seen, for example, in their treatments of symbol and myth.

SYMBOL AND MYTH

Differences in the way Lonergan and Whitehead view the concrete experience of the subject and the relationship of experience to thought are significant in accounting for their attitudes towards forms of religious expression such as symbol and myth.

Whitehead stresses that the relationship of thought to concrete experience is initially one of simplification. Thought excludes certain emotional and environmental factors which are important constituents of experience; it always excludes some aspects of an entity's character in removing it from its organic relationships. All language which deals with important realities therefore has a suggestive, elusive quality about it, and appeals to the imagination for comprehension. And symbolism is essential for the higher grades of life, even though its errors can never be totally eliminated.

Whitehead knew that the language of religious devotion can at times

¹ 'The Response of the Jesuit as Priest and Apostle in the Modern World', p. 172.

² *Method in Theology*, pp. 106-7.

³ *Religion in the Making*, p. 81. Cf. p. 83.

convey aspects of experience that more intellectualized forms of expression cannot: 'One of the reasons of the thinness of so much modern metaphysics is its neglect of this wealth of expression of ultimate meaning.' A familiar hymn, for example, can integrally link the concepts of flux and permanence which philosophy frequently sunders:

Abide with me;
Fast falls the eventide.¹

These convictions also account for Whitehead's deep appreciation of poetry.

Loneragan's statements on the mythic and symbolic have been frequently criticized, and the elements of that criticism will not be repeated here.² What is of interest in relation to Lonergan's view of experience, consciousness, and the concreteness of the subject is that, aside from his brief explicit discussion of the symbolic in *Method in Theology*, Lonergan's comments generally place the symbol at the level of undifferentiated consciousness where it fulfills the needs of common sense and concrete living. And concreteness here does not refer, as in Whitehead, to the full concrete actuality of relations in the universe. Situated within the context of a hierarchical ordering of the differentiations of human consciousness and the stages of meaning, such comments relegate the symbolic rather to the realm of elemental or potential meaning.

The most common type by far is undifferentiated consciousness. To this type will always belong the vast majority of the faithful. Because it is undifferentiated, it is only puzzled or amused by the oracles of religiously differentiated consciousness. . . . But within the limits of undifferentiated consciousness, there is no communication of doctrine except through the rituals, narrative forms, titles, parables, metaphors that are effective in the given milieu.³

Loneragan's comments on myth and symbol thus show a stronger preference for discursive over non-discursive forms than is found in Whitehead.

The category of Lonergan's which reveals a greater affinity to Whitehead's view of the concrete and the need for the symbolic is the 'known-unknown'. Whitehead speaks of the fact that it is easy to highlight the familiar and prominent features of life and leave inarticulate the elements which are on the edge of consciousness but fundamental to existence. Similarly, Lonergan, in speaking of religious experience, refers to the permanent quality of mystery in life, to a 'mysterious undertow',⁴ to 'some intimation of unplumbed

¹ *Process and Reality*, p. 318.

² See, for example, J. P. Mackey, 'Divine Revelation and Lonergan's Transcendent Method in Theology', and Jean-Pierre Jossua, 'Some Questions on the Place of Believing Experience in the Work of Bernard Lonergan', *Looking at Lonergan's Method*, ed. by Patrick Corcoran, S.M. (Dublin: The Talbot Press, 1975), chapters 10 and 11. For a helpful summary of Lonergan's treatment of myth and symbol, as well as a constructive critical assessment of his approach, see Edward K. Braxton, 'Bernard Lonergan's Hermeneutic of the Symbol', *The Irish Theological Quarterly*, XLIII (1976), 186-97.

³ *Method in Theology*, p. 276. Cf. pp. 305-9; 328-9; 'Natural Knowledge of God', *A Second Collection*, p. 132. Lonergan's explicit treatment of the symbol is found in *Method in Theology*, pp. 64-9.

⁴ 'The Response of the Jesuit as Priest and Apostle in the Modern World', p. 172.

depths that accrued to man's feelings, emotion, sentiments'.¹ This world of meaning which includes that which is partly known and familiar surrounded by regions never explored or not known at all reflects the same importance for symbolic forms as Whitehead's concrete realm of causal efficacy.

AMBIGUITY AND RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE

The contrast in the approaches which Lonergan and Whitehead take to the symbolic is also related to another aspect of their discussion of religious experience: the incorporation of the negative, and of ambiguity in such experience. One of the basic tenets of Whitehead's philosophy is that good and evil are ever-present aspects of the universe. In the concrete, good and evil are intertwined.² In the midst of an existence filled with frustration, pain, and loss, peace is the inner feeling which accompanies a grasp of the purpose of tragedy. Whitehead is working from a model of organic relationships rather than independent substances. Since religious experience is marked by the wide coordination required by value, and heavy with emotional connections, it is marked also by the ambiguity of such connectives. Religious experience, for Whitehead, involves the quest for a harmonious reconciling of compatibility and contrast.³ An aspect of the experience of God in this universe is the experience one has of ideals which have been entertained, aimed at, and achieved or lost. Both success and failure are important to that experience; the experience then indicates a relationship to a source of ideals.⁴ Whitehead serves several reminders that religion, though of the highest importance, is not necessarily good: 'Religion is the last refuge of human savagery'; some religions, in fact, 'conduce more to evil than to good'.⁵

Lonergan also recognizes that religious experience may be inauthentic, and that in addition to conversions there are breakdowns. His basis criterion for religious experience is authenticity: 'Its many aberrations can be accounted for by the precariousness of the human achievement of authenticity.'⁶ Religious development is dialectical, and advance is won only by continual withdrawals from inauthenticity. However, Lonergan's focus is not so much on religious self-transcendence as an ambiguous loss and gain, as on such transcendence as advance and fulfilment.

Such unconditional being-in-love actuates to the full the dynamic potentiality of the human spirit with its unrestricted reach and, as a full actuation, it is fulfilment, deep-set peace, the peace the world cannot give, abiding joy, the joy that remains despite humiliation and failure and privation and pain.⁷

¹ Lonergan, *Insight. A Study of Human Understanding* (New York: Harper and Row, 1978), p. 532.

² Cf. *Adventures of Ideas*, p. 18.

³ *Religion in the Making*, pp. 109–11, 115.

⁴ *Modes of Thought*, pp. 102–3.

⁵ *Religion in the Making*, pp. 17, 36.

⁶ *Philosophy of God and Theology*, p. 54.

⁷ 'Natural Knowledge of God', p. 129. Cf. 'Theology and Man's Future', *A Second Collection*, pp. 146–7; *Method in Theology*, pp. 110–11.

The world of Lonergan's account of religious experience is less marked than Whitehead's by the awareness of contrasts and incompatibilities, and the struggle with evil.

SOLITARINESS AND THE COMMUNAL

One final point of comparison between the two is the way in which their understanding of the concrete experience of subjects affects the manner in which religious experience is described as solitary or communal by Lonergan and Whitehead. In the closing section of the chapter on religion in *Method in Theology*, Lonergan states that 'however personal and intimate is religious experience, still it is not solitary'.¹ In contrast, one of Whitehead's most misunderstood and criticized comments on religion is that it is 'what the individual does with his own solitariness'.²

For both Lonergan and Whitehead, the social side of religion is important but not primary. According to Lonergan, the love which is involved in religious experience breaks through the isolation of the individual, causing him or her to function not just for the self but for others.³ Another communal dimension stressed by Lonergan is the fact that many individuals may come together as a result of sharing the same gift:

The same gift can be given to many, and the many can recognize in one another a common orientation in their living and feeling, in their criteria and their goals. From a common communion with God, there springs a religious community.⁴

Both of these statements of the relationship between the solitary and the communal are built on the substance/quality approach to reality, that of an independent subject who subsequently is related to others.

Whitehead's approach is based on radical relativity; the standard of actuality is subjects who are constituted by their experience of one another. On the one hand, Whitehead sees solitariness as especially important to certain aspects of religion:

The great religious conceptions which haunt the imaginations of civilized mankind are scenes of solitariness: Prometheus chained to his rock, Mahomet brooding in the desert, the meditations of the Buddha, the solitary Man on the Cross. It belongs to the depth of the religious spirit to have felt forsaken, even by God.⁵

But for Whitehead a person is always an individual in community, a self emerging from his or her relationships. And this relatedness moves beyond the human community to the structure of all of the relationships of the individual to the cosmos.⁶ The solitariness of the coming to be of an entity is also the condition of its freedom and responsible decision making; individual existence is a contribution to the future world:

¹ P. 118.

⁴ *Ibid.* p. 118.

² *Religion in the Making*, p. 16.

⁵ *Religion in the Making*, p. 19.

³ *Method in Theology*, p. 289.

⁶ *Modes of Thought*, p. 164.

The moment of religious consciousness starts from self-valuation, but it broadens into the concept of the world as a realm of adjusted values, mutually intensifying or mutually destructive.¹

Solitariness is the context in which one achieves the unity and individuality which enable one to make an original contribution in subsequent relating. God knows an entity as an object which has become, not as a subject which is coming to be. Whitehead therefore does not speak, as does Lonergan, of religious experience as the entering into 'a subject-to-subject relation with God'.²

Such then, are some dimensions of religious experience according to Lonergan and Whitehead. When dealing with two such complex and subtle thinkers, it is not easy to draw broad lines of agreement and disagreement. What becomes apparent in comparing their views, however, is the significance of Lonergan's shift to religious experience as a starting point for a philosophy of religion. In addition to the focus on the concrete experiencing subject already present in both systems, this shift opens up emphases which move Lonergan closer to Whitehead's notion of experience. In contemporary considerations on the reality of God, process thinkers and classical theists have frequently been found in opposing positions, especially when the discussion has turned to questions such as the temporality or non-temporality of God and his relatedness to a world of flux and change. Important contrasts remain between Lonergan and Whitehead, but when their accounts of religious experience are used as the basis for a comparison, these differences can be situated within large areas of similarity in their descriptions of such experience and its relationship to a philosophy of God.

¹ *Religion in the Making*, pp. 58–9.

² 'Natural Knowledge of God', p. 129.